always relied on my phone – and still do today – at the time I didn't even miss it.

That one phone call a day became a big deal. As soon as the last session of the day was over, I would race to the phone to make my call before supper, which they served at 7 p.m. There was always a queue of people wanting to use the phone. Despite the fact that the phone was at reception and you had no privacy, as someone was always watching you, on some nights there were so many people wanting to use the phone that you never got a chance.

As a – you know – 'public figure', I never felt embarrassed about being in rehab. Many of the other 'inmates' recognised me, and some of them couldn't believe that I was actually taking part in a session with them. The counsellors initially had to stop these guys from discussing cricket with me. I was happy to talk cricket, though, and during breaks we'd chat away. The Test series against Australia was taking place while I was in rehab, and there was one particular guy – an elderly chap, I'll call him George – who kept on asking me for the score. The room he was in didn't have a TV.

George was a huge cricket supporter and a fan of mine, and every morning I'd hear the tapping of his walking stick as he came towards my room, wanting to find out how the Test was progressing. The counsellors eventually got pretty pissed off with him. They said, 'Herschelle is here to deal with his alcohol problem. You can't keep on talking sport all the time.' I didn't mind George at all. I actually grew quite fond of the bloke. But eventually the counsellors threatened us with a 'warning' if they heard us talking about sport again. Apparently, if you accumulated three warnings they could kick you out the programme.

But George was a funny old oke – sneaky as hell. The minute the counsellors turned their backs, he would come and natter with me through my window. 'What's the score? What's the score, man?' He had a great sense of humour.

The actual rehab part of rehab would start at 7 a.m. with a group meeting. The first half an hour would be a quick recap – stuff like how were we feeling, were we missing anybody outside, was there something we wanted to get off our chests? People would talk about what it felt like to go cold turkey, and what they were craving or missing – booze, sex, friends, family. I never said much. I'd say something like, 'Well, I had a good night's sleep.' And I'd give them the latest cricket score.